

BORN IN BLOOD

This adventure is for four or five **9th-level characters** playing the fifth edition of the world's most popular roleplaying game.

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GM INFORMATION

BACKGROUND

- **Darghast**, a son of the vile sea god Dagon, has been born into the icy, black waters near the sleepy fishing town of Estinn.
- A generational **cult** within Estinn's oldest families secretly kept watch over Darghast's egg for 300 years while the godling incubated.
- Once Darghast hatched, those families threw off their disguises. They rounded up the hapless townsfolk of Estinn in a night of bloodshed and terror, sending them into the ocean for Darghast to **devour**.
- Only one person remains alive in Estinn, and not for long. Darghast's worshippers will soon go hunting for any remaining victims...

SYNOPSIS

- The characters are traveling to Estinn. The news of its **fall** has not yet reached the outside world.
- When the PCs arrive, they find a ravaged ghost town. A desperate **survivor** tells them of the terrible events over the last three days.
- The PCs confront Darghast's **cultists** and learn more about what happened to the townsfolk.
- The PCs follow a gory trail into the ocean. There, they find Darghast's victims, as well as his **stronghold**.
- Inside, the PCs overcome ancient wards and guardians so they can **confront** the godling.

RUNNING THE ADVENTURE

- This adventure is meant to be run at a glance. It uses bulleted lists, **bolded** keywords, and short room descriptions you can read or paraphrase and embellish as needed.
- Monsters have clickable links to their stats online or in this document.
- *Appendix A* contains GM versions of the adventure's maps.
- *Appendix B* has the stats and descriptions for new monsters.
- *Appendix C* has new magic items.
- You can watch a video walkthrough of the adventure [here](#).
- You can watch a video walkthrough for how to use the combat cards included with the adventure [here](#).

PACING/TRANSITIONS

- A **Dramatic Question** is presented with some encounters. Once that question has been answered, the tension of the scene is resolved. That's your cue to work toward the **Transition** — even if that means summarizing the end of a clearly decided encounter.
- Room descriptions are short and informational. Anything listed before the **Development** section is safe to share with the players at the outset. Reveal elements from the Development section as the characters explore the area.

GHOST TOWN

Establish why the characters are visiting the seaside town of Estinn. The adventure begins as they approach it.

THE TOWN OF ESTINN

- The **road** to Estinn is deserted.
- When the peaked roofs of the **town** come into sight, no sound carries on the chilly sea breeze gusting from its docks. The cobblestone streets are silent and the sooty chimneys unlit.
- The dark waters of the **bay** are empty of any sailboats or fishing vessels.

DEVELOPMENT

- The damp row **houses** are unlocked. There are no people inside them.

There are no signs of struggle, burglary, or packing up to leave in the first few homes the PCs check.

- Cobblestone streets wind through Estinn down to the **docks**. Dozens of sailboats are neatly moored there.
- A few stray dogs dart through the **streets**. They whine fearfully when they see the PCs and scuttle away.
- After a few minutes, the PCs catch sight of a **curtain** swinging in the window of a nearby house.

TRANSITION

- If the PCs investigate the curtain or town further, go to *A Lone Survivor*.
- If they head to the docks, go to *Tracks in the Sand*.

A LONE SURVIVOR

WENDEL'S HOUSE

- A squat **row house** has the curtains drawn tightly over its windows. A dented swordfish emblem hangs above the green-painted front door.
- A muted **crash** emanates from inside.

DEVELOPMENT

- Curtains block the **windows**. The front door's **lock** is broken.
- **Wendel** the fisherman lives here. The crash was him knocking over a pickling barrel in his cellar while trying to climb inside it to hide.
- Inside the dim **house** are worn furnishings, giant sea maps nailed to the walls, and fishing gear. An open jar of pickled fish sits out on a table.

One of the **maps** gently flutters.
Behind it is a staircase to the cellar.

- The damp **cellar** has rows of dusty shelves filled with pickling jars. Six oak barrels line the walls. A fresh puddle of brine seeps across the floor.

Wendel hides in one of the barrels.

Wendel Firg, CG human **commoner**

"I won't go peaceful-like! Stay back!"

- **Appearance.** Tanned, 40-ish man. Mop of black hair. Stinks of brine.
- **Does.** Threatens to hurl jars of pickled goods to defend himself.
- **Secret.** Ashamed he didn't try to help the other townsfolk.

DRAMATIC QUESTION

Will the PCs find and talk to Wendel?

TALKING TO WENDEL

- **Wendel** doesn't trust the PCs at first, but he opens up if they convince him they're not "with the town guard."
- He tells them that three nights ago, the town guard came door-to-door and made everyone go down to the docks for an "emergency meeting."

The **guards** looked seasick, all green and sweaty and bulge-eyed.

Wendel got a bad feeling and hid in the cellar. The guards broke into his house, but they didn't find him.

He's been watching out the windows as much as he dares. Nobody has come back yet.

At night, he hears gibbering **voices** yelling down by the docks.

HOOK: APPEAL TO HEROISM

- Wendel begs the PCs to help the townsfolk if they're in trouble.

HOOK: APPEAL TO DISCOVERY

- Wendel pleads with the PCs to find out what horror has befallen Estinn.

TRANSITION

- If the PCs go to the docks, go to *Tracks in the Sand*.

TRACKS IN THE SAND

DOCKS

- Estinn's streets funnel down to rows of barnacle-encrusted **docks** plunging out into the dark bay.

Dozens of sailboats and dinghies bob and clack in their moorings.

- A wide arc of sandy **beach** curves away from the docks on either side. The sand is churned up and scattered with dark patches and objects.

DEVELOPMENT

- 12 **deep ones** **hide** in the water beneath the docks. They have scaly green skin, protruding mouths lined with pointy teeth, and bulging eyes. They wear the torn remnants of their blue town guard uniforms.

The deep ones attack PCs who notice them or enter the water.

- The beach's **sand** is disturbed by the passage of 140 villagers. Brown patches of dried blood stain it.

Hats, spectacles, shoes, and cloaks litter the shoreline. Countless **footprints** lead to the water's edge.

COMBAT

- The 12 **deep ones** want to capture the PCs and sacrifice them to Darghast.

DRAMATIC QUESTION

Can the PCs defeat the deep ones and learn what happened to the townsfolk?

WHAT THE DEEP ONES KNOW

- Captured deep ones are craven and share the following if under threat:

They are members of the **Order of Dagon**. The Order is as old as Estinn itself, a secret religion handed down within the town's first families. Few know of it.

They began to **transform** into the "children of Dagon" once "Brother Darghast" hatched three days ago.

Darghast is their prince. He is a glorious terror to behold when unleashed, ever-hungering. He devoured the townsfolk.

TRANSITION

- If the PCs enter the water, go to *Shapes in the Water*.
- If they return to the town, go to *Ghost Town*.

SHAPES IN THE WATER

BEING UNDERWATER

This adventure uses the following simplified underwater rules:

- Creatures can hold their breath for 1 minute + CON modifier (1 min.).
- Bludgeoning weapons deal half damage. Otherwise, all weapons work normally.
- Movement is halved for creatures without a swim speed.

SEAWEED FIELDS

- The frigid, choppy waters of the bay extend all the way out past the grey clouds blanketing the horizon.
- A forest of slimy **seaweed** crowds the water 100 feet from shore.

Ghostly, pale **shapes** are visible in the seaweed from the surface.

DRAMATIC QUESTION

Will the characters swim out into the dark water toward Darghast's lair?

DEVELOPMENT

- Beneath the water's surface 100' from shore, dozens of drowned **townsfolk** are tangled in the dense seaweed. Their bodies are raggedly torn apart.
- 60' down, a dropoff **shelf** lies before a curtain of black water.

PCs with darkvision or a light source who peer into the dropoff from its edge catch sight of a giant, carved **pillar** (60' tall) rising from the ocean floor 100' away. Larger shapes loom beyond it.

- At the edge of the shelf, a limestone **statue** of a towering fish-man with a tail instead of legs looks toward shore.

PCs trained in esoteric lore recognize the statue as Dagon, an obscure, chaotic evil sea god.

Humanoids who touch the statue and say Dagon's name gain the effects of a **water breathing** spell.

TRANSITION

- If the PCs swim out past the shelf, go to *Darghast's Lair*.

DARGHAST'S LAIR

AREA 1: THE COLUMNS

- Three leaning **columns** thrust out of the seabed to form a wide triangle. Barnacles and worn carvings cover their surface.
- Between the columns, four jagged **pits** gape in the rocky ocean floor.
- Schools of pale, fat-throated **fish** swirl through the murky water.

DEVELOPMENT

- The **columns** bear heiroglyphics of fish, whales, octopi, and sharks.

PCs who know Deep Speech can decipher their message: "Here dreams Darghast, son of Dagon."

- The **pits** lead into narrow tunnels. PCs who listen at the entrances hear a faint, guttural chanting echoing up the tunnel to Area 5.

The tunnels are cramped and lined in yellow, sticky mucus. Creatures traversing them must pass a DC 15 Dexterity save each round or have one of their worn or carried items get **stuck** in the mucus. It requires a DC 18 Strength (Athletics) check to free an item.

A *Cloak of the Manta Ray* stuck in the wall mucus leading to Area 2.

- The **fish**, if communicated with magically, say they saw a shoal of "sea walkers" (deep ones) enter the pits a few hours ago. They can't count and so don't know how many.

TRANSITION

- If the PCs take the east tunnel, go to Area 2 in *The Boiling Fane*.
- If they take the central tunnels, go to Areas 4 or 5 in *Central Caves*.
- If they take the west tunnel, go to Area 7 in *West Caves*.

THE BOILING FANE

AREA 2: SHARK CARVINGS

- Every inch of the stone walls and ceiling are covered in carved, realistic **reliefs** of hundreds of sharks.
- The double **doors** to the south shift and undulate slightly.

DEVELOPMENT

- The detailed **shark carvings** are in all sizes and poses. Some are full profiles, some just a face jutting from the wall.

One small carving has an arm-sized hole reaching into its gullet. Inside is a recently severed human hand clutching a star-shaped **sapphire pendant** worth 150 gp.

- Scorching hot water seeps through the **doors'** seams from Area 3. It causes the doors to appear to waver.

Any creatures within 20 feet of the open doors must pass a DC 15 Dexterity save or take 5d6 fire damage (half on a success) as **boiling water** pours out of Area 3.

AREA 3: INCUBATION ROOM

- A **statue** of a serpentine beast with neck fins and dozens of clawed legs looms high overhead. It glows red-hot, as if it were iron heated by flame.
- A sparkling layer of gold coins and gems covers the floor.
- The scorching **water** swirls and churns in turbulent eddies.

DEVELOPMENT

- The **statue** is a (mostly) petrified aquatic **remorhaz** (swim speed 30 feet, can breathe underwater).

Its claws grip a punctured, alabaster egg as big as an ogre.

Each time a creature other than a deep one **touches** the statue, it has a cumulative 1:4 chance of ending the petrification. The furious **remorhaz** attacks anyone it sees.

- A creature must make a DC 15 Constitution save each round while in Area 3. It takes **5d6 fire damage** on a failure (half on a success).

TREASURE

- Scattered around the floor are: 400 gp, 3 bloodstones (40 gp each), 2 pieces of red coral (80 gp each), and 5 pieces of moonstone (50 gp each).

TRANSITION

- If the PCs return to the outside, go to Area 1 in *Darghast's Lair*.

CENTRAL CAVES

AREA 4: CULTIST STATUES

- Four worn, limestone **statues** of humans stand around the room. Clusters of black barnacles sprout on their arms and faces.

DEVELOPMENT

- The **statues** depict contorted humans with toothy mouths, slit noses, bulging eyes, and hooded cloaks.

Each has a weighty **sharktooth necklace** on a leather cord placed around its neck. Creatures wearing these are immune to **Darghast's Dominate** ability.

A **word** is carved onto the base of each: Morell, Hawthorn, Grimms, and Burton. PCs proficient in Intelligence (History) or who pass a DC 18 History check recognize these as local surnames.

One of the statues has a white **pearl** for an eye (80 gp) with a miniscule castle map etched on it.

AREA 5: WHISPERING TRENCH

- A black **pit** as wide around as a galleon fills the floor.
- Smooth bas-relief **carvings** cover the limestone walls.

DEVELOPMENT

- The **pit** is a 100-foot deep trench. All sources of light dampen to nothing when placed inside. A pale **giant shark** with milky, deep-sea eyes swims in circles at the bottom of it.

Sibilant **whispers** rise out of the pit when a creature looks inside. Creatures who ask the pit a question in Deep Speech receive a short, truthful answer in return.

Each time after the first question, there's a cumulative 1:4 chance the **giant shark** lunges from the pit to bite at the questioner. It swims back down into the darkness.

- The **carvings** show scenes of a giant fish-man (Dagon) with a tail instead of legs grappling with sea creatures of equal size, including a blue whale, a megalodon shark, and a giant squid.

TRANSITION

- If the PCs head north, go to Area 8 in *Prince of Sharks*.
- If they travel west, go to Area 6 in *West Caves*.
- If the PCs return to the outside, go to Area 1 in *Darghast's Lair*.

WEST CAVES

AREA 6: PRISONER

- A **man** sags against the wall, arms and legs pinned to the stone by rope bindings passed through iron spikes.

DEVELOPMENT

- The man is **Petyr**, a town guard from Estinn. He's from the Dagon-worshipping families who turned into deep ones when Darghast hatched. His lack of faith caused his transformation to fail.

The **deep ones** (Area 8) plan to lock Petyr into Darghast's cage (Area 8) tomorrow and watch the carnage.

- Petyr was an underling in the cult and doesn't know much of the lair's layout. He shares what he knows with the characters.

Then, he asks the PC to pass **judgment** on him and decide his fate; he accepts their decision.

Petyr Morell, NG human **guard**

"Best kill me before Darghast does!"

- **Appearance.** A young man in torn, blue town guard robes. Thin gills shudder and strain on his neck.
- **Does.** Gasps desperately through his weak gills for breath.
- **Secret.** Never loyal to Dagon. Was horrified at the cultists' actions in Estinn and rebelled.

DRAMATIC QUESTION

Will the characters help Petyr?

WHAT PETYR KNOWS

- Six deep ones in the caves tend to a horror called **Darghast**, a godling with an endless hunger for human flesh.
- They wear special sharktooth **necklaces** to keep the god from "hypnotizing" them.
- They barely have Darghast under **control**; he would devour them if they didn't lock him in a cage with the help of a magic trident they carry.

AREA 7: SLIME ORBS

- Yellow orbs of **slime** bubble off the walls and drift through the water.

DEVELOPMENT

- There are 20 **slime orbs** floating around. They burst in a 10-foot radius shower of poison when touched (DC 15 Constitution save or 2d6 poison damage, half on a success).

PCs can pass a DC 15 Dexterity save to **grab** an orb without rupturing it. Orbs merge if carefully joined (2d6 poison damage per merged orb).

TRANSITION

- If the PCs travel southeast, go to Area 5 in *Central Caves*.
- If they return to the outside, go to Area 1 in *Darghast's Lair*.

PRINCE OF SHARKS

AREA 8: DARGHAST'S HALL

- Beside the **stone door** to this room is a thick lever made of iron.
- Beyond the door, burbling **voices** chant slobbering, rhythmic words in a rising and falling chorus. It's punctuated by howling screams.

DEVELOPMENT

- The **door** can be barred from the outside, but it's currently open. When barred, it's DC 23 to break open.

The **lever** outside locks/unlocks Darghast's cage (see below).

- Inside the room, **Darghast** thrashes and screams inside an adamantine **cage**. His albino skin covers a sleek, humanlike body with gills, a fin, and a fat neck that opens into a shark maw.

Darghast Dominates anyone not wearing a sharktooth necklace (Area 4) and demands release.

- Six **deep ones** chant odes to Darghast in Deep Speech. They ritualistically stab villagers' corpses onto the sharp, red coral jutting from the walls.

The **coral** deals 2d6 piercing damage to any creature it touches.

All five deep ones wear sharktooth **necklaces** (Area 4), making them immune to Darghast's domination. One also carries a *Trident of Dagon* (see *Appendix C: Magic Items*), which they use to force Darghast back into his cage after he eats.

COMBAT

- If two or more **deep ones** die, they scramble to release Darghast and use the *Trident of Dagon* to control him.
- If **released**, bloodthirsty Darghast mows through any creatures near to him, including deep ones.

Darghast promises to spare any creatures who release him (a lie).

DRAMATIC QUESTION

Can the characters defeat the cultists and decide what to do with Darghast?

TRANSITION

- Once the characters have dealt with Darghast and the deep ones, go to the *Aftermath*.

AFTERMATH

DEFEATING DARGHAST

- Any remaining deep ones **flee** in terror, abandoning Estinn and the surrounding waters.
- **Dagon** visits the characters in their dreams on a future night, appearing as a titanic deep one that lunges out of a black sea to tower overhead. He glares down at the characters with burning, yellow eyes, and then sinks slowly back into the water.

LEAVING DARGHAST ALIVE

- If the PCs leave immortal Darghast inside his **cage**, he eventually breaks out after many long years and goes on a savage killing and devouring spree.
- The Prince of Sharks is an eldritch being the PCs might try to **ally** with instead of kill. If they can convince Darghast of their worth over the “pitiful fishlings his father left him,” he can become their patron and offer them potent magical boons — as long as they continue to bring him innocents to devour, of course.

ESTINN

- Estinn becomes an empty **ghost town** with all of its villagers dead. The rumors surrounding its fall are too dreadful for anyone else to risk moving there.
- If **Wendel Firg** survived, he leaves Estinn behind and moves to a fully landlocked city, where he opens a pickling shop.

FUTURE ADVENTURE HOOKS

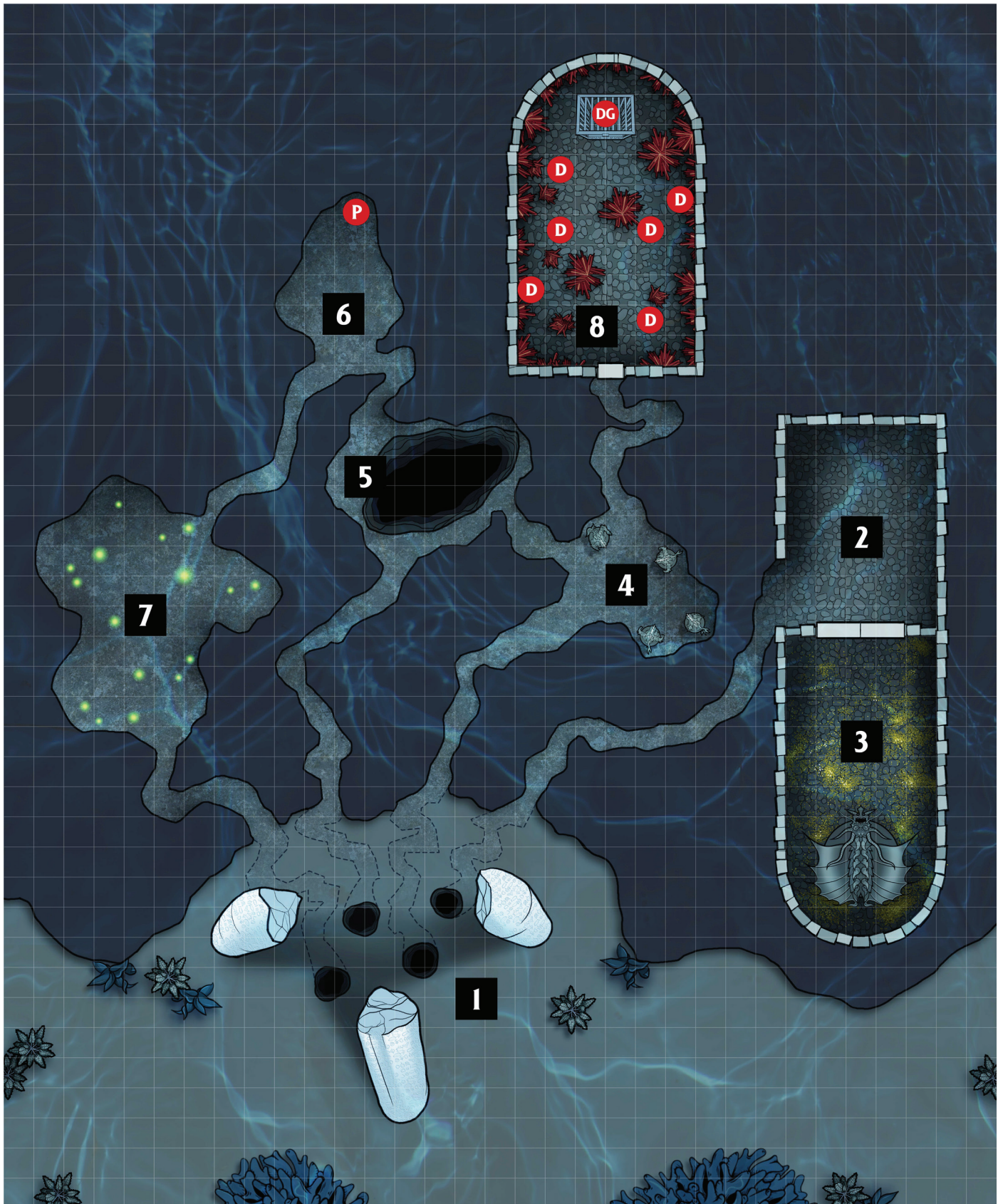
- If the characters allied with **Petyr Morell**, he tells them that several deep ones from Estinn have already gone searching outside the town for new victims to bring to Darghast. Who will they bring back, and what will they find when they return to Estinn?
- Other **Cults of Dagon** might exist in nearby towns and villages. Can the characters root them out and stop Dagon’s other abominable children from hatching?
- After Estinn falls to ruin, a powerful band of **sahuagin** slink out of the sea and take it over. There, they establish a fortified stronghold and begin raids into the surrounding towns...
- The characters are haunted by nightmares of an **obelisk** in a wet cave that echoes with the burbling, sickening chants of countless deep ones. Is this a real location? Who is sending the characters these dreams?

APPENDIX A: MAPS

THE DOCKS



DARGHAST'S LAIR



APPENDIX B: MONSTERS

DEEP ONES

Green-scaled humanoids with fins in place of ears, bulging eyes, and fang-lined mouths. Their webbed feet and hands allow them to swim effortlessly.

Ageless. Deep ones don't age and are effectively immortal, but they can be slain. They continue to grow larger with each passing decade. Some deep ones have grown so large and ancient that their power blossoms into new, eldritch abilities; some rumors say that their god, Dagon, is the eldest deep one.

Lost Culture. Forbidden texts hint that there are ancient cities populated by deep ones in the darkest fathoms of the sea or in subterranean lakes buried beneath the earth. Ancient, sinister wonders swim among the curling spires, limestone temples, and emerald domes of these cruel cities.

Hidden Lineage. Humanoids with a deep one parent do not express any of their deep one traits until a triggering event, such as the nearby presence of Dagon, or another eldritch incident activates their transformation into a deep one.

These potential deep ones may not ever know the truth of their lineage, while others strive to bring about their transformation by summoning Dagon or finding the god's hidden sites of power.

Some potential deep ones are horrified by their transformation and are able to resist it, but others are drawn by the temptation of power and immortality and embrace the change fully.

DEEP ONE

Medium humanoid (deep one), neutral evil

Armor Class 15 (natural armor)

Hit Points 65 (10d8 + 20)

Speed 30 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)

Skills Perception +3

Proficiency +2

Damage Resistances cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13

Languages Common, Deep Speech

Challenge 2 (450 XP)

Amphibious. Deep ones can breathe air and water.

Immortal. Deep ones do not age.

Slippery. When a deep one would take damage as a result of passing a saving throw, it takes no damage instead.

Legendary Resistance (1/Day). If the deep one fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The deep one makes two claw attacks.

Claw. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) slashing damage.

DARGHAST, SON OF DAGON

A sleek man-shark with alabaster skin, corded muscles, and glossy, black eyes. A dorsal fin protrudes from his spine and gills line his barrel-like neck. His jaw distends open into an oversized mouth with three rows of shark teeth crusted in blood and gore.

Child of Titans. Darghast is a lesser god. His father is the vile sea god of the deep ones, Dagon. His mother is an ageless, albino megalodon of the black depths where primal monstrosities devour each other and only the most savage killers survive.

Prince of Sharks. All sharks naturally recognize Darghast as an apex predator above even their own fearsome power. They treat him with deference and obey his commands.

DARGHAST

Medium aberration, chaotic evil

Armor Class 16 (natural armor)

Hit Points 171 (18d8 + 90)

Speed 30 ft., swim 60 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	16 (+3)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)	20 (+5)

Saving Throws Wis +7

Skills Perception +7

Proficiency +4

Damage Immunities cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Condition Immunities frightened, paralyzed

Senses blindsight 60 ft., darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 17

Languages Common, Deep Speech

Challenge 12 (8,400 XP)

Amphibious. Darghast can breathe air and water.

Digest. Darghast digests material instantly and never becomes full.

Legendary Resistance (3/Day). If Darghast fails a saving throw, he can choose to succeed instead.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Darghast makes 3 bite attacks.

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 18 (3d6 + 5) piercing damage.

Dominate. Darghast casts *dominate monster*. The Wisdom saving throw DC is 17.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

Darghast can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one legendary action option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature's turn. Darghast regains spent legendary actions at the start of his turn.

Bite. Darghast makes one bite attack.

Circle. Darghast swims up to 60 feet. This movement does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Dominate (Costs 2 Actions). Darghast uses his Dominate ability.

APPENDIX C: MAGIC ITEMS

TRIDENT OF DAGON

Weapon (trident), Rare, requires attunement by a creature who worships Dagon

- This bronze, two-pronged trident has green, crawling runes etched onto its blade and haft. It's a +1 magic weapon.
- **Orate.** You can speak Deep Speech while you are attuned to the trident. Once per day, if you give a rousing sermon in Deep Speech for at least 1 minute, all followers of Dagon who heard you gain inspiration.
- **Control.** Once per day, you can use an action to cast *dominate monster* from the trident (Wisdom save DC 17). If the target is a direct offspring of Dagon, the target does not get to make a saving throw.

CREDITS

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BEING UNDERWATER

This adventure uses the following simplified underwater rules:

- Creatures can hold their breath for 1 minute + CON modifier (1 min.).
- Bludgeoning weapons deal half damage. Otherwise, all weapons work normally.
- Movement is halved for creatures without a swim speed.

Petyr Morell, NG human **guard**

"Best kill me before Darghast does!"

- **Appearance.** A young man in torn, blue town guard robes. Thin gills shudder and strain on his neck.
- **Does.** Gasps desperately through his weak gills for breath.
- **Secret.** Never loyal to Dagon. Was horrified at the cultists' actions in Estinn and rebelled.

Wendel Firg, CG human **commoner**

"I won't go peaceful-like! Stay back!"

- **Appearance.** Tanned, 40-ish man. Mop of black hair. Stinks of brine.
- **Does.** Threatens to hurl jars of pickled goods to defend himself.
- **Secret.** Ashamed he didn't try to help the other townsfolk.

- **Dagon:** A vile sea god who dwells in the deep ocean and rules a kingdom of immortal deep ones.
- **Darghast:** Shark godling who is the offspring of Dagon and an albino megalodon. Recently hatched after several centuries of incubating under the protection of the Order of Dagon.
- **Estinn:** Small fishing town situated on a chilly bay of dark water.
- **Order of Dagon:** Secret cult of Dagon passed down by the Morell, Hawthorn, Grimms, and Burton families in Estinn.